STOCKHOLM, SWEDEN

Nationalmuseum: Masterpieces

Twenty works about gatherings, solitary tasks and the surroundings that make a portrait.



A dance, a breakfast table and an evening gathering offer three different ways of bringing people together. In these works, companionship does not require everyone to look at everyone else. It may be established by turning bodies, a pool of lamplight or a table prepared for a meal. The solitary figures are equally specific: a hand supports a head, a woman writes, a painter works outdoors in snow.

This selection moves between Swedish painting and works by Rembrandt, Zurbarán, Renoir and Cézanne. Instead of treating them as a procession of national schools, follow the forms of attention they describe: how someone looks, waits, works or shares a space.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/nationalmuseum-stockholm

The selection · 20

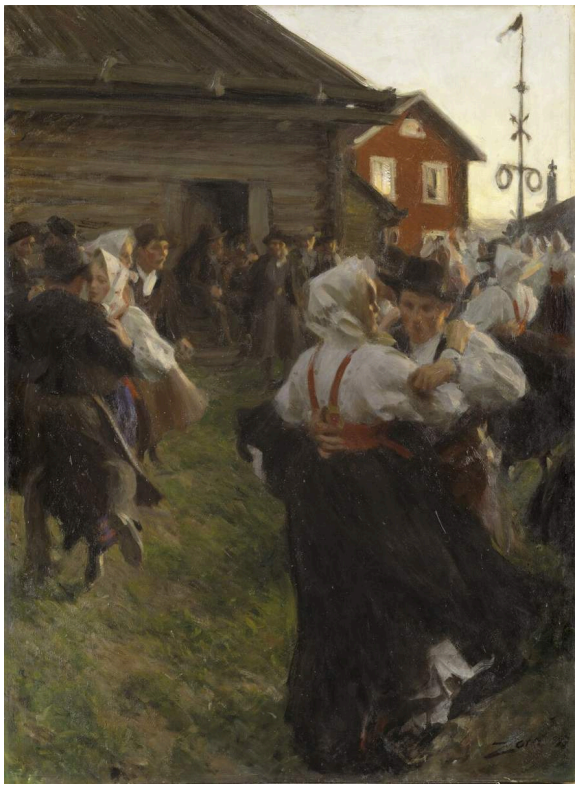
1. Midsummer Dance
   Anders Zorn · Signed 1897
2. The Kitchen Maid
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1651
3. Blossoming Acacia Branches
   Vincent van Gogh · 1890
4. Simeon in the Temple
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1669
5. The Conspiracy of the Batavians
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1662
6. Carl Gustaf Tessin
   François Boucher · 1740
7. The Holy Face
   Francisco de Zurbarán · c. 1631
8. The Inn of Mother Anthony
   Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1866
9. Friends
   Hanna Hirsch-Pauli · 1907–1910
10. Breakfast Time
    Hanna Hirsch-Pauli · 1887
11. Marie Suzanne Roslin, née Giroust
    Alexander Roslin · Signed 1763
12. Carl Linnaeus
    Alexander Roslin · 1775
13. Our Daily Bread
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14. Sea Eagles
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15. Fox in a Winter Landscape
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16. Portrait of the Artist’s Wife
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17. Open-Air Painter: Winter Motif from Åsögatan
    Carl Larsson · Signed 1886
18. A Day of Celebration
    Carl Larsson · c. 1895
19. Letter-Writing
    Carl Larsson · 1912
20. Murre: Portrait of Casimir Laurin
    Carl Larsson · 1900

01 / 20

Midsummer Dance

Anders Zorn

Signed 1897 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



Anders Zorn. Midsummer Dance. Anders Zorn; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Midsummer_Dance_(Anders_Zorn)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_18607.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The maypole is not the painting's centre. Zorn gives more space to the turning couples, whose shirts catch the lingering night light. His account of the work describes painting after sunset in June and July. The particular light therefore belongs to the picture's making as well as to its subject: this is a night scene that does not become dark.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 1603

02 / 20

The Kitchen Maid

Rembrandt van Rijn

1651 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



Rembrandt van Rijn. The Kitchen Maid. Image credit: Rembrandt; Source credit: Nationalmuseum. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The hand pressed against the woman’s head makes resting an action with weight. Her red clothing and pale linen emerge from darkness, but the ledge also holds her close to the spectator. Whatever the traditional title suggests about her occupation, the picture’s immediate subject is this particular arrangement of a person pausing.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM584

03 / 20

Blossoming Acacia Branches

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



Blossoming Acacia Branches. WikiArt; Vincent van Gogh. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

There is no distant view through which to approach the flowers. Yellow blossom and green leaves fill the field, their directions established by clustered strokes. Some branches are easy to follow; others disappear into the surrounding marks. Growth is presented as an entanglement rather than a botanical diagram with each part isolated.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Simeon in the Temple

Rembrandt van Rijn

1669 · Nationalmuseum



Simeon in the Temple. WikiArt; Rembrandt van Rijn. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The child’s small body rests in an old man’s hands, and the contrast of scale supplies the scene’s essential relation. Faces and wrapping emerge without equally clear surroundings. This concentration keeps the biblical encounter close to an act of handling: the significance of the infant is conveyed through how carefully he is received.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Conspiracy of the Batavians

Rembrandt van Rijn

1662 · Oil · Nationalmuseum



The Conspiracy of the Batavians. WikiArt; Rembrandt van Rijn. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The swords bring separate men into a common action above the illuminated table. Some faces remain difficult to distinguish, while the convergence is clear. Rembrandt gives the oath a collective form without making every participant equally legible. The light joins them around a decision rather than presenting a row of independent portraits.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Carl Gustaf Tessin

François Boucher

1740 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



Portrait of Carl Gustaf Tessin. WikiArt; François Boucher. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Books, a globe and a sheet held in the hand surround Tessin with the materials of cultivated public life. His turned face prevents the composition from reading simply as an inventory of possessions. The objects establish a role; the relaxed interruption of his attention makes that role appear inhabited.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

The Holy Face

Francisco de Zurbarán

c. 1631 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



Francisco de Zurbarán. The Holy Face. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francisco-de-zurbaran/the-holy-face · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The face is faint, but the cloth that bears it has sharply described folds and shadows. That difference reverses the normal expectation that a sacred likeness should be the most solid part of an image. Zurbarán asks attention to pass through a convincingly material object before arriving at the less tangible face upon it.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

The Inn of Mother Anthony

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1866 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



The Inn of Mother Anthony. WikiArt; Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The white cloth gives the gathered figures a common centre, while their differing positions keep the meal from becoming a formal line-up. A dog occupies the near space below them. The arrangement leaves room for ordinary bodily adjustments around a table, making companionship visible through shared occupation rather than an announced emotion.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Friends

Hanna Hirsch-Pauli

1907–1910 · Nationalmuseum



Hanna Hirsch-Pauli. Friends. Image credit: Hanna Pauli (1864 - 1940) (Swedish) Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: wgGTWIkYzTLaDQ at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The lamp distributes attention unevenly. Some members of the group are close to its light; others belong to the room’s shadows. This does not prevent the painting from functioning as a group portrait. The gathering is held together by a shared situation, allowing individual visibility to vary rather than requiring every face to make its claim.

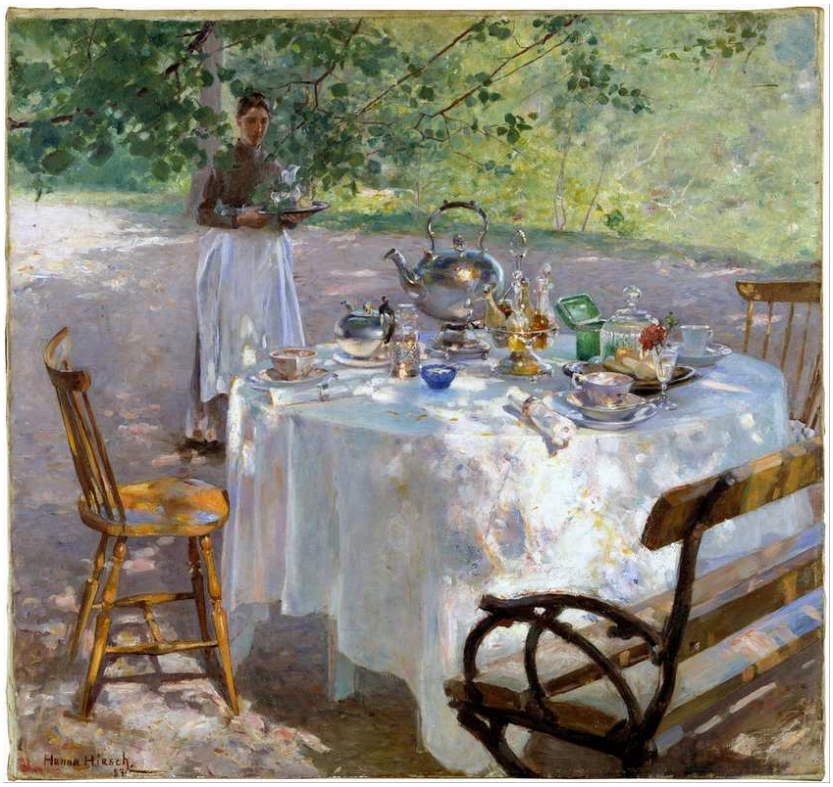
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 1723

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Breakfast Time

Hanna Hirsch-Pauli

1887 · Nationalmuseum



Hanna Hirsch-Pauli. Breakfast Time. Image credit: Hanna Hirsch-Pauli. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The breakfast table is prepared before it is fully occupied. On the white cloth, glass, silver and crockery break the daylight into smaller incidents. The woman beyond the table has company in the objects themselves: a domestic occasion is established through what has been arranged and made ready, not simply through the number of people present.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 1705

11 / 20

Marie Suzanne Roslin, née Giroust

Alexander Roslin

Signed 1763 · Nationalmuseum



Alexander Roslin. Portrait of the Artist's Wife Marie Suzanne, née Giroust. Alexander Roslin; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction); Åsa Lundén / Nationalmuseum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Portrait_of_the_Artist%27s_Wife_Marie_Suzanne,_n%C3%A9e_Giroust_(Alexander_Roslin)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_18014.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Flowers near the shoulder and hair accompany the sitter’s turning pose. Gathered fabric carries that movement away from the face, making the portrait less rigid without making the likeness disappear into decoration. The effect depends on restraint: the accessories support the turn rather than demanding an independent reading of every flower.

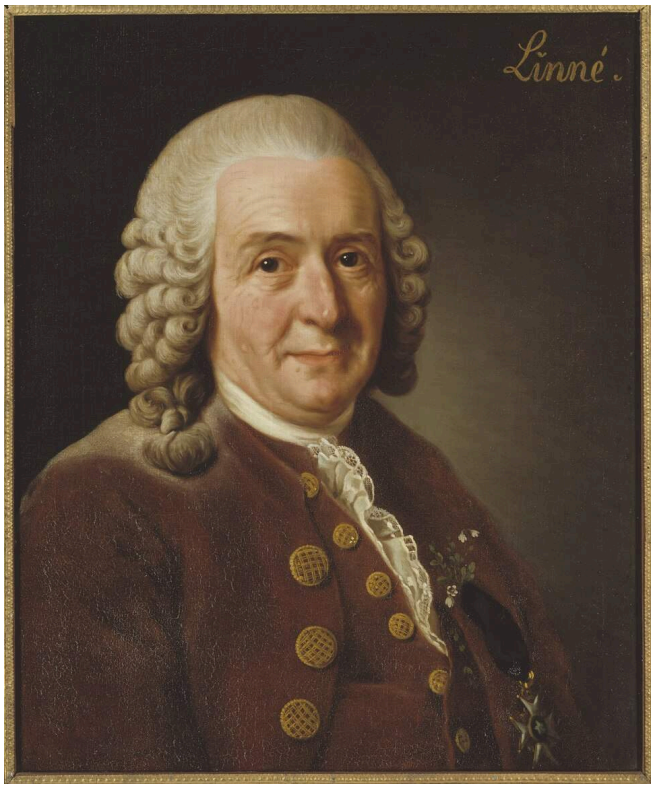
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 1011

12 / 20

Carl Linnaeus

Alexander Roslin

1775 · Nationalmuseum



Alexander Roslin. Carl Linnaeus (1707–1778), Professor and Botanist, 1775. Alexander Roslin; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Carl_von_Linn%C3%A9,_1707-1778,_botanist,_professor_(Alexander_Roslin)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_15723.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The plant near Linnaeus's chest is a small detail beside the dark coat, bright buttons and powdered wig. Its scale makes the professional reference unobtrusive, yet specific. Roslin keeps the conventions of a formal likeness while allowing a botanical subject to enter the sitter's immediate space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMGrh 1053

13 / 20

Our Daily Bread

Anders Zorn

Signed 1886-09 · Watercolour · Nationalmuseum



Anders Zorn. Our Daily Bread. Anders Zorn; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction); Erik Cornelius / Nationalmuseum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Our_Daily_Bread_(Anders_Zorn)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_24125.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The seated woman and steaming pot occupy the near ground; work continues in the field beyond. The meal is consequently neither an isolated still life nor a separate domestic occasion. It belongs to the same day of labour. The distance between resting and working bodies gives that relationship a visible form.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMB 184

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Sea Eagles

Bruno Liljefors

Signed 1897 · Nationalmuseum



Bruno Liljefors. Sea Eagles. Bruno Liljefors; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction); Erik Cornelius / Nationalmuseum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Sea_Eagles_(Bruno_Liljefors)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_18508.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The birds' extended wings create competing angles over the rough shore. Their bodies have to be understood in motion, not merely recognised by their plumage. Pale sea behind them helps make the wings' reach legible. Liljefors leaves the animals within an environment while giving their actions enough weight to organise it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 1505

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Fox in a Winter Landscape

Bruno Liljefors

Signed 1938 · Nationalmuseum



Bruno Liljefors. Fox in Winter Landscape. Bruno Liljefors; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction); Per-Åke Persson / Nationalmuseum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Fox_in_Winter_Landscape_(Bruno_Liljefors)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_23703.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The fox's warm coat distinguishes it from the snow, yet the surrounding branches keep interrupting an easy view. Its visibility depends on the landscape rather than on a neutral background. The picture therefore rewards attention to both animal and cover: the setting is part of the encounter, not decorative space around a specimen.

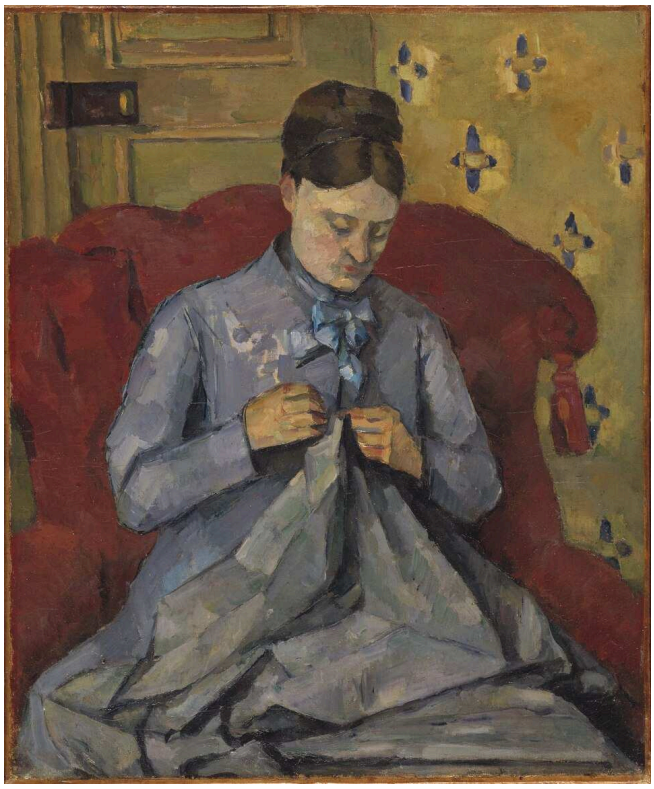
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 6654

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Portrait of the Artist’s Wife

Paul Cézanne

1877 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



Paul Cézanne. Portrait of the Artist's Wife. Paul Cézanne; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction); Erik Cornelius / Nationalmuseum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Portrait_of_the_Artist%27s_Wife_(Paul_C%C3%A9zanne)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_23397.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The red armchair gives the seated figure a firm enclosure. Her head inclines toward her hands, directing attention away from an exchange of looks with the spectator. Broad areas of colour preserve the weight of the body and furniture; the private occupation remains legible without disclosing a thought behind it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 6348

17 / 20

Open-Air Painter: Winter Motif from Åsögatan

Carl Larsson

Signed 1886 · Oil on canvas · Nationalmuseum



Carl Larsson. Open-Air Painter. Winter-Motif from Åsögatan 145, Stockholm. Carl Larsson; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Open-Air_Painter._Winter-Motif_from_%C3%85s%C3%B6gatan_145,_Stockholm_(Carl_Larsson)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_19607.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Equipment in the foreground gives outdoor painting practical dimensions. The snow-covered yard is both the subject of the picture and the place where a painter must stand to observe it. Larsson includes that second condition. The result makes a useful comparison with landscapes that conceal every trace of the work required to produce them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NM 2546

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A Day of Celebration

Carl Larsson

c. 1895 · Watercolour · Nationalmuseum



Carl Larsson. A Day of Celebration. From A Home (26 watercolours). Carl Larsson; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction); Erik Cornelius / Nationalmuseum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:A_Day_of_Celebration._From_A_Home_(26_watercolours)_(Carl_Larsson)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_24221.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Decorated beams, doors, rails and furniture divide the celebration into smaller episodes. The figures do not have to gather at one central point for the room to hold them together. Repeated colours and architectural boundaries carry attention between them, showing how a designed interior can participate in an occasion.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMB 280

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Letter-Writing

Carl Larsson

1912 · Watercolour on paper · Nationalmuseum



Carl Larsson. Letter-Writing. Carl Larsson; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction); Erik Cornelius / Nationalmuseum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Letter-Writing_(Carl_Larsson)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_25407.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The letter’s contents remain private. What the picture offers instead is the writer’s bent posture and the setting that makes the task possible: desk, window, plants and surrounding woodwork. A modest action gains specificity from its place. There is no need to invent the message in order to understand the concentration.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMB 1438

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Murre: Portrait of Casimir Laurin

Carl Larsson

1900 · Watercolour on paper · Nationalmuseum



Carl Larsson. "Murre". Portrait of Casimir Laurin. Carl Larsson; Nationalmuseum, Sweden (museum-contributed reproduction). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Murre_._Portrait_of_Casimir_Laurin_(Carl_Larsson)_-_Nationalmuseum_-_90181.tif. Public Domain Mark (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The rocking horse places the child’s seated pose on a different footing from an adult portrait. Its curved runners and the red coat give the small figure a clear setting within the heavier furniture. The toy remains recognisable as an object for movement, even while its rider holds still for a likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NMB 2528

Compare a pause with a gathering

Put *The Kitchen Maid* beside *Friends*, or *Letter-Writing* beside *Breakfast Time*. Each pair distinguishes private attention from a shared occasion without reducing either to a fixed mood. Holdings and display are different questions; check the museum’s current listings before planning around a particular work.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

The chapters on tone and the arrangement of a picture offer a practical companion to Pauli, Zorn and Liljefors. Compare their different uses of a bright surface or dark silhouette before applying a general stylistic label.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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